Mussalman, but I know not the existence of any other religion than these two.' For Kuar Man Singh, if both Hinduism and Islam were recognizable and acceptable options, the Padshah's proposed system of allegiance to what appeared to be a new religious cult was suspect, and Akbar did not push the matter further.

Another special courtier, Mirza Aziz Koka, was more scathing of Akbar's religious innovations. In a letter to the Padshah when he was en route to Mecca, Aziz Koka wrote about the extraordinary claims his old childhood companion appeared to be making: 'There have been rulers who commanded great power and authority but it never occurred to anyone of them to advance a claim for Prophet-hood and strive to abrogate the religion of Muhammad,' admonished Aziz Koka. As for those who had chosen to become Akbar's disciples, he was even more scornful. 'O my God, who are the people who claim to become the four friends,' railed Aziz Koka. 'By God and by the dust of the Emperor's feet, there is none except Aziz Koka who wants a good name, all others depend on flattery and passing out time.' Accusing all the disciples of being vain sycophants, Aziz Koka added that they 'have preferred infidels over Muslims and this will remain imprinted on the pages of the days and nights'. So disgusted was Aziz Koka at the destabilizing changes at court that he stormed away in a great sulk, claiming he needed to grow out his beard. He did not return even after Akbar grew exasperated and chided him saying, 'You are making all these delays in coming; evidently the wool of your beard weighs heavily on you.'

Despite the high bombast of Mirza Aziz Koka's letter, he would come to regret these bruising sentiments after his sojourn in Mecca. But that would be later, and for now, having lit up the night of Fatehpur Sikri with embers too hot to behold, Akbar set off for a hunt in the Faizabad region. On the way the Mughal retinue passed the 'Gung Mahal', and Akbar decided to visit it, to see how the children were faring in their hushed silence. As we have seen earlier, Akbar found that 'not a sound was emitted from the silent house nor any speech came out of that place of residence. They displayed nothing beyond the usual gestures of the dumb. Whatever his majesty had, in his wisdom, realised some years earlier', said Badauni, 'now became clear to the superficial worldly ones, and it became a source of enlightenment to a large number of people.' There was no universal language, Akbar realized, having put the idea to the test.